ADVOCATING WELLNESS THROUGH PHYSICAL FITNESS

Human bipedalism is a cherished feature. Starting from a toddler's first steps, human beings look forward to their exceptional abilities of being on their feet. However, ill health and diseases sometimes leads to deprivation of this most important physical function that promotes human mobility. This spectrum of decline can be associated with aging or may result from a wide variety of diseases. Just like any other human function, when mobility is derailed individuals face enormous challenges including falls and sharp decrease in quality of life. An important repertoire of providers who works silently behind the scene in restoring physical mobility involve physical therapists. Abhijit Sahoo caught up with Dr. Venkata Amar Kumar Nuthalapati to discuss the clinical significance of his practice. He has special interests in multiple sclerosis and was involved with Woodlands Care Center in York, UK.

"My goal is to help individuals regain independence and maintain a high quality of life through personalized treatment plans and continuous physical rehabilitation", stated Dr. Nuthalapati. Dr. Nuthalapati, currently associated with Amedisys Health Care at Maryland in the United States has been instrumental with his relentless efforts in motivating and improving home healthcare. Excerpts of the discussion are below.



Dr. Venkata Amar Kumar Nuthalapati
Home Health Physical Therapist

What are your responsibilities as a physical therapist in a home based care scenario?

The most significant role that I perform is providing optimal care to patients. It is important for personalized treatment plans tailored to each patient's specific needs and goals. I foster a collaborative relationship with the patients and their relatives, empowering them to actively participate in their care

What are the main techniques that you utilize?

Since the early days formal methods of physical therapy, machines have been used to enhance mobility. The first evidence comes from the use of "Gymnasticon" by Francis Lowndes for exercising the joints in gout. My approach integrates exercise therapy, manual techniques, and electrotherapy to effectively manage physical impairments and support the rehabilitation process.

How significant is patient education for your care?

Patient education plays a vital role in physiotherapy by equipping individuals with the knowledge and confidence needed to take an active role in their own recovery process.

How physiotherapy supports overall wellness for all ages?

Everyday activities like lifting groceries, sitting erroneously or sleeping in awkward positions can cause pain, but physiotherapy helps improve balance.

What strategies do you use to support the physical, emotional, and cognitive well-being of elderly patients in a home care setting?

Although exercise is beneficial for everyone, it can present certain risks—particularly for elderly adults with medical conditions such as heart disease, high blood pressure, osteoporosis, or previous injuries. Physical therapy allows these individuals to engage in physical activity safely, with proper guidance, which helps minimize the risk of exercise-related injuries over time. Unexpected slips and falls can occur at any time. Research indicates that falls among elderly frequently lead to serious health complications. Tai-chi and core strengthening are of great help.

How do you collaborate with patients to establish and reach practical therapy goals?

Collaborating with patients to set and achieve realistic therapy goals is a key aspect of home-based physical therapy. I track progress regularly and make necessary adjustments to the plan to keep the patient aligned with their goals and motivated throughout the recovery process.

How do you incorporate health and wellness promotion into your physical therapy practice, especially when working with aging or home-bound patients?

Physical therapy doesn't stop when a client leaves the session—it's just the starting point. To be truly effective, we need to understand how each patient's views on health and wellness influence their behaviors and lifestyle choices. This means recognizing both the broader connection between wellness and physical therapy, as well as the unique factors that shape each individual's experience. Wellness provides the purpose behind our work. My goal is to enhance our clients' quality of life by helping them move with greater freedom and live more fully.

What are some of the most common health disparities that impact access to physical therapy services?

In a landmark report in 2003, the Institute of Medicine (National Academy of Medicine) published Unequal Treatment; Confronting Racial and Ethnic Disparities in Healthcare. This is often an unacknowledged problem and pervasive even in the realm of my practice area of physical medicine. The opportunities for home visits is a great ameliorative step in providing access to care for all individuals.

What is your final advice Dr. Nuthalapati?

We have a lot of lessons to learn from people who live in the "Blue zone". The moto should be to lead a comfortably uncomfortable life.